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ANAND SHARMA

the same wavelength”.

There is another reason why Pawar is trusted implicitly by the prime minister—unlike other allies such as the DMK and Trinamool Congress, the NCP chief prefers to deal directly with the PMO instead of the UPA chairperson. Last year, when sundry sycophantic Congressmen raised Rahul Gandhi's name as prime minister for E-2009, Pawar was the first to state that his candidate remained Manmohan. With only nine MPs, the NCP is the smallest coalition partner in the UPA. Yet, Pawar's stature comes not from his numbers but from his image. He is not just one of the Cabinet heavyweights, but also knows how to sway a consensus. During the nuclear deal, he played troubleshooter with the Left on behalf of the PMO. While the DMK and Trinamool Congress oppose some of the Government's pro-reform moves such as its ambitious disinvestment agenda, Manmohan can always count on Pawar's support. The respect is mutual. During the recent Bt brinjal controversy when Pawar took on the Environment Ministry and shot off a 16-page letter to the prime minister, Manmohan gave him a sympathetic hearing. He knows that cutting across party lines (and this includes his own party), this is the one man he can trust.

■ Anand Sharma

INDUSTRY AND COMMERCE MINISTER

THE LIBERAL FACE

Twenty days after he took over as the industry and commerce minister, Anand Sharma made a startling pronouncement, claiming that the Doha impasse at the World Trade Organisation talks had been broken. The trade talks had come to a standstill in 2008 with Sharma's predecessor Kamal Nath taking a tough line on the issue of special safeguard mechanisms that allowed poor countries to impose special tariffs on agricultural goods in the event of a surge. However, a former external affairs minister, Sharma opted for the more diplomatic option and indicated that India was still a contender in the talks. Incidentally, this is a line that has the reformist prime minister's go-ahead.

The articulate Sharma is the prime minister's calling card in the international stage. In the era of economic diplomacy, he certainly has the right credentials for the job. His familiarity with the global arena was visible at Davos recently where he successfully pitched India's growth story to world leaders wearing a rather flamboyant red tie. It was as party spokesman that he impressed 10 Janpath, it was as the information and broadcasting minister

during the last few months of the UPA Government's earlier stint that he caught the prime minister's eye with his rather detailed campaign highlighting the Government's achievements during the run-up to the polls. In the current Government, Sharma is also the bridge between 10 Janpath and the PMO. He was also a vocal defender of the prime minister's favourite nuclear deal. The loquacious minister's dizzying rise in the UPA Government defies gravity but explains the Manmohan-Sharma chemistry.

■ Prithviraj Chavan

PMO, PARLIAMENTARY AFFAIRS, PERSONNEL, SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY MINISTER

THE SUAVE INTERPRETER

Manmohan's lone ranger brand of politics needs a political troubleshooter at the Prime Minister's Office. Prithviraj Chavan, his affable minister of state, is not just the prime minister's link between 10 Janpath and South Block, but also works as a complaint centre for those MPs who have a wish list for the prime minister. The low profile Chavan has Sonia Gandhi's trust while his pro-reforms ideology appeals to Manmohan's instinctive brand of economics. Unlike some of his ministerial colleagues, he is also smart enough not to play politics between the two which made him hard to replace particularly in Manmohan's PMO which looks to 10 Janpath for political direction. As the Berkeley educated minister had held the same PMO portfolio during UPA-I, Chavan had hinted that he wanted a change. To compensate, he was given the science and technology portfolio with independent charge.

Whether it is the nuclear deal or the equally tricky issue of Bt brinjal, Chavan's views are in sync with Manmohan and he is often fielded to test the political waters before the Prime Minister reveals his position. It is not nuclear science, he's just playing elementary politics. ■

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PRITHVIRAJ CHAVAN